



Resistance to Philip II's claim on the Portuguese crown in 1580 was weak—while an army advanced on Lisbon, the Spanish fleet assaulted it from the sea.

THE PUBLICATION IN DRESDEN

of the *Book of Concord* in 1580 was a pivotal moment in the development of **Lutheranism** (see 1516–18). While reaffirming the supreme importance of the Holy Scriptures—the Bible—it set out a strict interpretation of them “as the unanimous consensus and exposition of our Christian faith.” It remains the basis of Lutheran beliefs today.

Philip II of Spain's claim to the **Portuguese crown** after the throne became vacant (see 1578–79) was made good in August 1580 by a combination of military force and bribery.



Francis, Duke of Anjou
Foreign support—English or French—was essential to defeat the Spanish, so the Dutch Protestants made the Duke of Anjou their ruler.

“NOTHING IS SO **FIRMLY BELIEVED AS THAT WHICH LEAST IS KNOWN.**”

Michel de Montaigne, French Renaissance writer, *Essais* Book I

In July 1581, the northern provinces of the Netherlands—the **United Provinces**—declared their independence by the **Act of Abjuration**, renouncing their oaths of loyalty to Philip II. With the Spanish king now technically deposed, a new throne, that of the Netherlands, was created and accepted by the **Duke of Anjou** (1555–84), brother of Henry III of France. The south remained broadly loyal to Philip, but the Act's

assertion that a **legal king could be legally overthrown** would have significant consequences.

The impact of the **Single Whip Reform**, or “simple rule,” in 1581 in **Ming China** was immense. The reform meant that not only would all taxes be based on property—itsself recorded in a universal census—but they would be **paid in silver**. It was introduced to simplify China's tax system and to avoid problems of inflation created by a paper currency and debased coinage. It was made possible by the inflow of Spanish and Japanese silver. The new tax system created even greater demand for bullion, raised the price of silver still further, and in the long term contributed to destabilizing the entire Ming economy.



Toyotomi Hideyoshi's victory at Shizugatake in May 1583 was typical of his ruthless deployment of overwhelming force against his enemies.

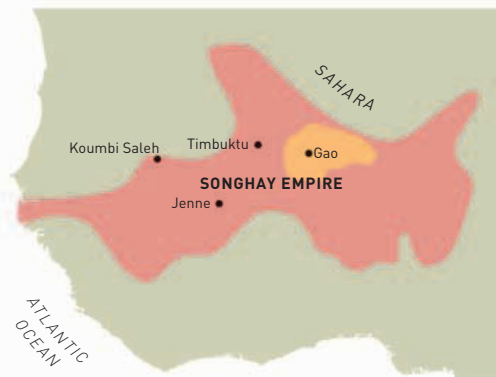
THE RITUAL SUICIDE OF ODA

NOBUNAGA (see 1560–62) in 1582 brought to power his most able general, **Toyotomi Hideyoshi** (c. 1536/37–98). Within a decade, he had succeeded in **unifying almost the whole of Japan** under his rule. It was a remarkable achievement for one born a peasant. All non-samurai were disarmed to ensure that commoners could not challenge his authority, while his reorganization of the tax system and redistribution of land guaranteed the revenues needed to complete his conquests.

On February 24, 1582, **Pope Gregory XIII** (1502–85) decreed a **revision to the Julian Calendar**, introduced in 46 BCE, which underestimated the length of every year by 11 minutes. By the late 16th century, the Julian date was 10 days adrift from the actual date, meaning that the spring equinox, from which the date of

Songhay Empire

The death of Askia Daud in 1582 followed by the Moroccan invasion (see 1591) were key factors in the Songhay Empire's decline.



KEY

■ Songhay territory in 1500
■ Songhay territory in 1625

Easter was calculated, fell on March 11 rather than March 21. Thus, for doctrinal reasons, the pope's modest adjustment was made. The change was introduced in October—Thursday the 4th being followed by Friday the 15th—but only in Spain, Portugal, Italy, and Poland-Lithuania. The rest of Europe, especially Protestant Europe, scenting a popish plot, was much slower to follow suit.



Sir Francis Drake (1540–96)

became the first English captain to circumnavigate the globe in 1577–80, renewing English interest in the New World. **Sir Humphrey Gilbert** had already voyaged to **Newfoundland** in 1578–79. In 1583, he returned, with Elizabeth I's backing, and claimed it for England. In 1584, again with royal approval, **Sir Walter Raleigh** (c. 1552–1618) sent an expedition to found the **Virginia Colony**, named for the “Virgin Queen.” It was established the following year at Roanoke Island, today in North Carolina, but, by 1590, it had disappeared.

The **surrender of Antwerp** on August 17, 1585, to the Duke of Parma was not merely a striking **military triumph for Spain**, but it also brought the city's commercial preeminence to an abrupt end.

Siege of Antwerp

The 13-month siege reduced the city's population from 100,000 to 40,000, but it returned the southern Netherlands to Spanish control.

